

Former arts minister opens Athy exhibition



ATHY, 2 June 2000: by [Mark McLoughlin](#). **Michael D Higgins TD** officially opened an exhibition of watercolour paintings by the renowned **local artist James H Flack** in the **Athy Heritage Centre** on Wednesday. James Flack (pictured above with the deputy) is originally from Co Armagh but settled in Athy in the early 1970s.

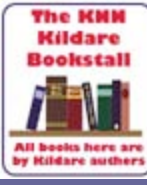


James Flack was also presented with an award by the **Athy UDC sub committee for arts and culture** for his outstanding achievements as a national and international artist.

The exhibition will run until 30 June, 2000, Mon-Sat 10am - 5pm and Sunday 2pm - 5 pm. Mr Flack will also **host a painting demonstration** on Thursday 15 June at 7.30pm. Enquiries to the Athy Heritage centre Tel: 0507-33075

Michael D Higgins also took time out to visit the **Athy Community Council's Barge Restoration Project** where chairperson **Monica Langton** explained to him that the barge will be in operation by August of this year. The deputy was particularly interested in this as when he was **Minister for Arts, Culture and the Gaeltacht** he was involved in the original plan to restore the barge. The 54m vessel was built in 1928 and was recently rechristened 'Aiseiri'.





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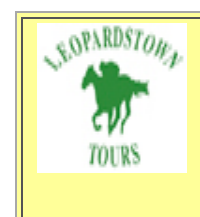
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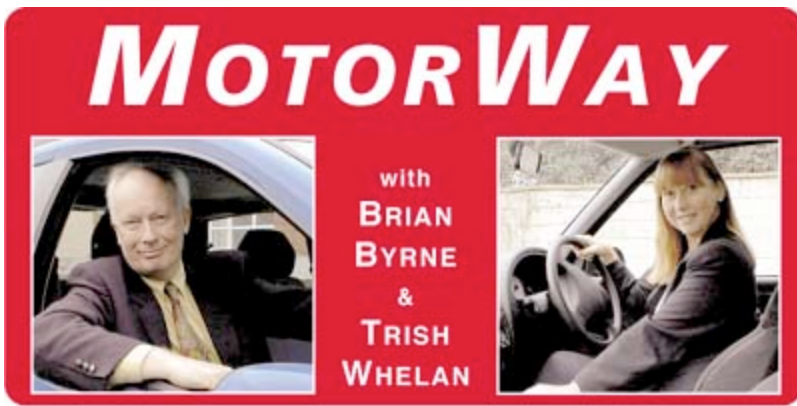
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Many objectors to Oldtown houses



NAAS, 2 June 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). Naas UDC has **extended for one month** the date for their decision on a planning application by **Quando Ltd** for 310 houses in **Oldtown Demesne** (above) on the Sallins Road in Naas. The new date is June 28.

A **very large number of objections** against the proposal have been lodged with the Council. Most objectors say the increase in the volume of traffic with the new houses **will cause a traffic hazard** on the road which is 'already overburdened with traffic and is unsafe'. They claim the Sallins Road is a residential road and should have a volume of traffic at a level **suitable for a residential area** - much lower than at present.

Flan Garry, the chairman of Spring Gardens Residents' Association, rejected any suggestion that construction vehicles would access the Sallins Road via the town. He said the entrance/exit to the Quando site is on a very dangerous stretch of road. He believes a more suitable one should be agreed. The **Spring Gardens Residents** also note that: "If **Naas GAA** are prevented from relocating to the de Burgh estate as recently reported, it would be **a direct contravention** of the 1999 Naas Development Plan.'

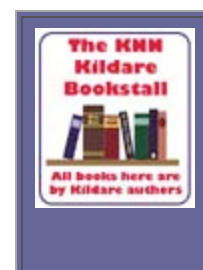
Mary McCarthy and **Jackie Birkett** from the **Sallins Road Action Group** say

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rezoning was allowed for 35 acres of residential land in the Oldtown area, and **want to know why** Quando can apply for a further 3.5 acres of additional lands to be included as parkland/landscaping when the criteria is for this open space to be included in the rezoned area. They refer to provision in the de Burgh Estate for a new **600-pupil school**, a **nursing home** (subsequently withdrawn), a **bowling alley**, a **9-screen cinema**, swimming pool/leisure centre and the relocation of Naas GAA, and say while the **sod was turned** in September 1998 for the 100-bed hotel, **no planning application** has been lodged for any of these amenities, except for further houses. They also ask why the development could not access the new road network further out the Sallins Road, given that the same developers are also involved there.

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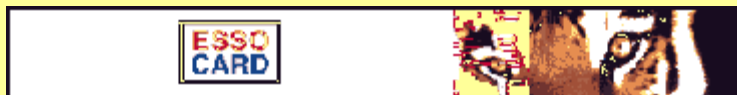
Bernard McPoland from **Sunday's Well** said the proposed houses and apartments 'would **obstruct the view of the canal**, to be made a special amenity area'.

A number of Sallins Road residents said the 310 houses would result in **1,085 extra people** living on the Sallins Road (3.5 persons per household being the County Kildare average) and the development, in conjunction with other planning applications already lodged with the UDC, would result in the 22,000 population cap in the 1999, 5-year development plan almost being surpassed only one year after its adoption.

Ian Ashe who has lived in the general area for the past eight years says he has seen the surrounding environment 'develop' from what was a pleasant and idyllic area into a **mass urban sprawl** of cloned housing estates built for the ever-growing population of Dublin'.

Nell O'Driscoll from Monread Court objected because school facilities in Naas are **inadequate to meet demand**. "There should have been a new Primary School in the town already as the population grew with 5,000 people or more over the last 10 years. Post Primary Schools have a waiting list for 1st year students. CBS Secondary School has 23 boys on the waiting list and St Mary's College had to turn away 30 students last year. If people are moving to Naas during the school year, it will be **highly unlikely** they will be able to get a place for their children in primary or secondary level."

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Market House is £330,000 heritage location

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KILDARE, 2 June 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). Kildare's historic **Market House** is to be the location of a new **£330,000 heritage centre** for the town, under a funding arrangement involving the **EU, Kildare County Council and local contributions**. The building has been a centrepiece for Kildare since the **early part of the 19th century** and was restored in 1973. It houses a number of armorial stones, including the **Castledillon** gravestone, and a nearby statue of St Brigid commemorates the 350 men slaughtered at **Gibbet Rath** on the Curragh in 1798. A white marble cross near the building is in **memory of local men** who were killed in 1922.

A **development campaign** to source sponsorship from individuals, businesses and companies in Kildare was launched recently, and the new centre will be built under the guidance of **architect and heritage consultant Orna Hanly**. The planned building will provide an **orientation service** for visitors to the town, directing them to the area's many tourist and heritage attractions. It will accommodate a tourist information office in cooperation with **Midlands-East Regional Tourism**.

Kildare was granted **heritage town status** in 1994. **Kildare Heritage Town Company Ltd** was formed to establish the centre, with representatives from the **Kildare Historical Society, Cairde Bhride, Kildare Chamber of Commerce, and Kildare Cathedral Committee**, as well as **Kildare County Council**.

Further information from **Anna Marie Delaney** at 873836.

Meanwhile, good progress is being made on the **pedestrianisation** of the Market Square area (below) in Kildare.





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Columb Brazil joins world's largest estate agency brand



NAAS, 2 June 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#).
Local auctioneer **Columb Brazil** has joined the worldwide network of RE/MAX franchises, the **largest estate agency** business in the world, which means properties he offers for sale will now be promoted in all RE/MAX franchises throughout the company as well as on its internet website.

RE/MAX, started in **Denver, Colorado**, in 1973, operates in 34 countries and plans to set up 75 franchises throughout Ireland linked by a computerised system.

RE/MAX regional owner **Dennis Curtin** (on left with Columb Brazil), on a recent visit to Columb's office in Naas, said in its four months in this country, it **now has 15 franchised offices**, ahead of schedule. It hopes to expand this by another 15 franchises this year.

Mr Curtin says the advantages are that each area is able to maintain and **keep the local estate agent with their own identity and expertise** in their particular market. Columb will have the RE/MAX franchise for his offices in Naas, Newbridge and Portlaoise.



Columb says it's a **very competitive market here** with lots of movements in and out of the county. "We're competing for buyers as well as sellers so to come under the RE/MAX international brand name will help us a lot." He points out that **one in 12 people who read a RE/MAX property website** buys from the company. He believes the majority of properties will soon be **marketed through technology** rather than through front window auctioneers, with would-be purchasers viewing properties on the

internet, in the comfort of their own homes.

Up to 60% of house buyers in this area **come from Dublin** and the new link with RE/MAX opens up new possibilities. "It's like having an office in Dublin ourselves." Columb Brazil says.

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Notes ... Notes ... Notes ...

KILDARE: Kildare County Council's engineering department is not prepared to clean up an illegal halting site being used by a traveller family in Kildare town. This was revealed by **Cllr Sean O Fearghail** at Monday's meeting of the authority. The same family had spent some years parked in a UDC centre town carpark in Naas. Cllr O Fearghail said two other sites to which this family might be moved had been identified. "It's going to be difficult to get public support for settled travellers if we continue to allow travellers to park illegally and keep it in such a poor condition," he said and asked county manager Niall Bradley what could be done to solve 'this very serious problem'.

SUNCROFT: A right of way between a number of houses at **Churchview Estate** in Suncroft is to be extinguished following agreement of Kildare councillors at Monday's meeting of the authority. The Kildare Area Committee at its meeting of 31 July 1998 had agreed the closing off of the alleyway of houses 3578/3579 and the gable end of No 2850 Churchview Estate be investigated.

CLANE: Pictured right at the recent presentation of Gaisce President's Awards to students of Scoil Mhuire in Clane are **Fr Denis Harrington**, PP Clane; **Cllr Michael Fitzpatrick** and **Paddy Behan**, a member of the Board of Management.



CELBRIDGE: Kildare County Council has agreed a proposed material contravention of the County Development Plan from change of use from an office to a crèche for **Jenny Maher** of Croghan House in Celbridge. The application was for retention of change of use.



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KILDARE GENERAL: Some 20 steam-powered vehicles, including traction engines from all over Ireland and the UK, passed through Kildare at the weekend on their week-long run from Dublin to Cork to raise funds for the Irish Wheelchair Association. The event was organised by Naas man Sean O'Gorman, who has long been a traction engine fan.



COUNTY HALL: Kildare County Council has approved a £300 fee for new limousine licences, similar to a new hackney licence. It was agreed that limousine operators could pay £150 to renew a licence; £30 to transfer the licence to another vehicle and £15 for a substitute vehicle.

MAYNOOTH: Maynooth Labour Branch raised £3,657 for the local Senior Citizens Committee through the Tony Smith Memorial Walk, which took place on Sunday. The walk was led off by Deputy Emmet Stagg and Cllr John McGinley, and included a route through Carton Estate.

KILCULLEN: There was a good turnout on Saturday night last for an 'Evening of Music and Fun' at Kilcullen's Town Hall Theatre, featuring the Nas na Riogh Singers, singer Noel O'Grady and a sketch based on a night with some of Ireland's literary giants written and produced by Bernard Berney. The event was in aid of the Kilcullen Lions support for a Sheltered Housing project.

NAAS: Gardai in Naas report a number of assaults on the streets in Naas in recent weeks. Investigations are ongoing with a view to bringing charges in as many cases as possible, according to Sgt Kevin Gralton. He said a number of people appeared before Naas Court on Wednesday 10 in connection with a Public Order disturbance at Fair Green and one person convicted of assaulting the arresting Garda was fined £500.

ATHY: An exhibition of art and photography will be held at Athy Community Library between June 6-24. It will be presented by the VTOS and will incorporate mixed media - oils, watercolours, chalk, acrylics and stained glass. All the photographic work is developed and mounted by the students in the VTOS, using their own darkroom facilities.

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Sallins Road proposals more than double traffic access points



NAAS, 1 June 2000: by [Trish Whelan & Brian Byrne](#). Current proposals before Naas UDC would involve the **making of five new public entrances and exits** onto a short section of the **Sallins Road**. They include an entrance for a proposed **hotel**, an entrance and exit to a **filling station and retail units**, an entrance to a **showroom** building, a combined entrance to an **apartments** complex and **school** and an entrance to a **leisure/sports complex**.

All would be between **Cherrygrove Estate** and (not including) the new **Monread junction** currently being upgraded as part of the access to Millennium Park. There are **already three exits** onto the road in the section, from estates in the Oldtown/Monread area east of the Sallins Road.

The plans are in proposals lodged with Naas UDC by **Green Project Management** on 24 May under a **Traffic Management Plan** prepared by Consulting Engineers **Malone O'Regan**. The report has been submitted as



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'unsolicited' extra information by **Quando Ltd**, who have applied for a 310-unit housing development on Oldtown Demesne.



The plan shows that the **access position for the hotel has been agreed** and is indicated on the planning permission for that project. The petrol station is intended to access directly from **two separate points** onto the Sallins Road and requires two crossovers (entrance/exit points) to operate successfully.

The showroom is intended to access onto the Sallins Road and a 'school road' which will also serve an apartments complex aligned with the Sallins Road. In the Oldtown development the residential, leisure and GAA developments are intended to have **a common access point** - the 'Oldtown junction'.

The access proposed for the hotel is a 'priority junction' with a right turning lane for traffic from the Sallins direction. Traffic flows from the school junction would also warrant a priority junction. The consultants recommend a **signal-controlled** crossing.



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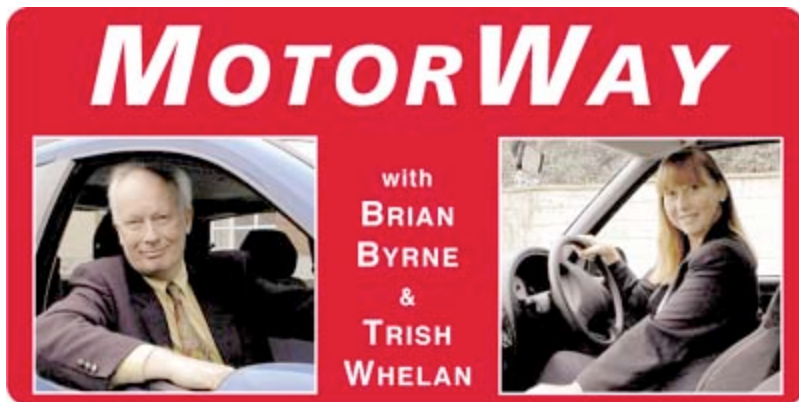


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Curragh historical monuments 'should not be signposted'



THE CURRAGH, 1 June 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). **Historical monuments** on the Curragh Plains should not be signposted because this would 'only encourage people to go to them'. That was the view expressed by a recent meeting on **the future of the Curragh** area as a sustainable recreational resource.

The meeting was under the auspices of the SRUNA PROJECT, an EU-backed initiative which is aimed at assessing and planning for the **sustainable recreational use of natural assets**. The Curragh is one of a number of pilot projects in the Dublin Region under the initiative, and the local project has been managed by **Kildare County Council's** Planning Department.

Project coordinator **Hazel McCarthy** said the area 'should not be turned into a **theme park**' and if signs were put up for the various monuments, 'people would inevitably go' to them. "Then you would have to **manage those people**, and possibly **fence in** the monuments to prevent their degradation," she said.

Other members of the group - which included representatives from the **Army**, **sheep farmers** with grazing rights on the plains, and the **bloodstock industry** - agreed that it wouldn't be a good idea to signpost the monuments, and that those people actually interested in them 'would go and **find them for themselves**'.

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The group also produced a 10-point '**Code of Conduct**' for the Curragh which, among other things, **prohibits vehicles from parking** or driving on the grass on any part of the plains. It also restricts golfing activities to the existing golf clubs in the area. Use of horses should only be for those with special '**licenses**' or '**permits**'.

Meanwhile, the **Curragh Task Force** set up by the Government to make recommendations on the future management of the area has **issued its report**. As [previously reported](#) on KNN, its proposals include setting up a full-time **Authority** for the management of the Curragh plains area, the preparation of an **Environmental Policy Statement** along with detailed archaeological and ecological surveys, and a review of all existing use of the plains.

The Task Force says **no further lands** should be licenced or leased to sports clubs, and where developments have taken place that are considered inappropriate, 'efforts should be made to rectify the situation'. Implementing the proposals would cost about **£600,000** in the first full year of operation.



[20 May 2000](#): Naas Moat Club wins All-Ireland ... waste initiative launched in Leixlip ... St Patrick's Community College to move.

This is a [KNN](#) broadcast production in [RealAudio](#).

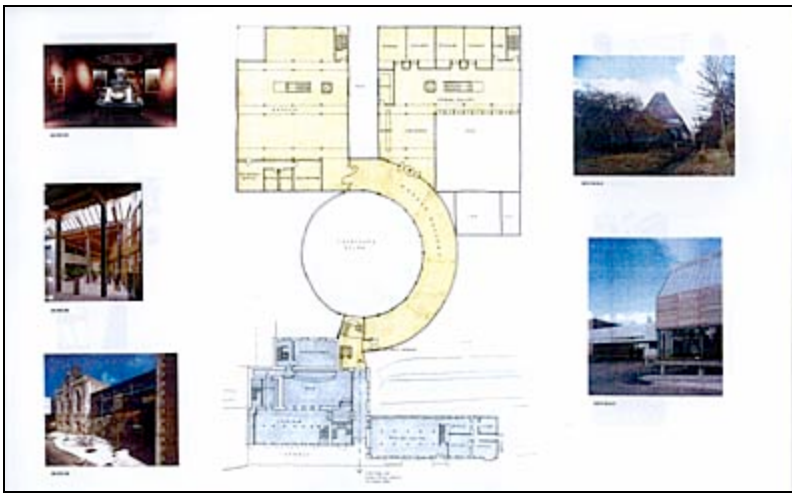
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County Museum proposal to councillors



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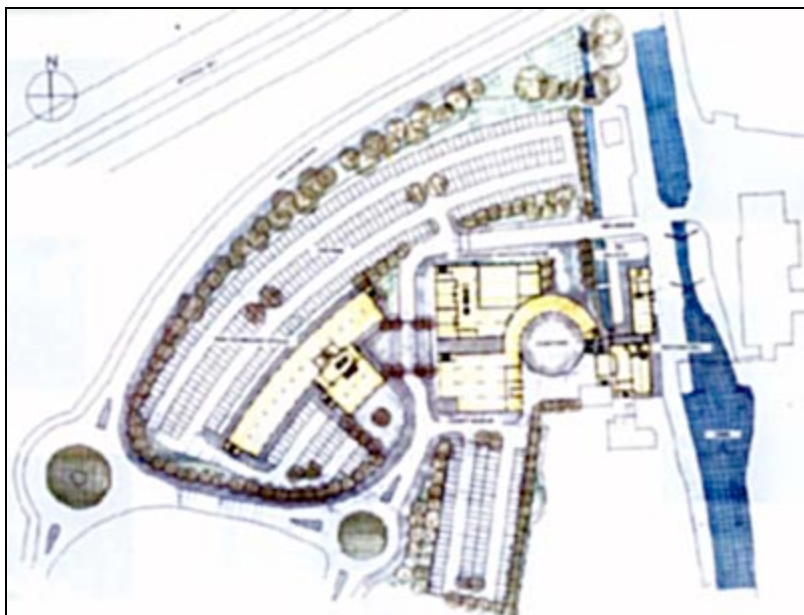
COUNTY HALL & NAAS, 1 June 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). Kildare councillors are to ask the **promoters of a proposal** to locate a **County Museum** on a site adjoining the old **Leinster Mills** on the canal in Naas to come before them and **make a formal presentation**. Councillors have already been circulated with an outline of the proposal, prepared by **Henry J Lyons and Partners**. Leinster Mills is now the headquarters for the **Millennium Park** business campus project.

KNN understands that Millennium Park developer **Gerry Conlan** and former Naas UDC member **Paddy Behan** have already met with Naas Area councillors and have put forward proposals, under which Millennium Park would **provide the site** and £250,000. It is believed the full cost of the plan would be in the order of £3 million.

In the proposal, the museum would be on **two storeys** and be part of a complex which would also include a **County Kildare Failte** office, an office for the **Inland Waterways**, a design centre, cafe/restaurant, a **conference/education centre**, high-technology '**incubation**' units and a creche. It would be linked to the restored 18th century Leinster Mills buildings.

The promoters suggest that **public bodies would be invited to participate** in the fundraising for the project, and the running costs would be covered by an **entrance fee** as well as **rent or profits** from a gift shop and restaurant. A fund would also be set aside for the purchase of items of Kildare interest which may come up for sale, while other artifacts and exhibits might be donated or loaned from present owners.

In total, the proposals provide for **1,400 sq mts of floor space**, half of which would be display galleries.



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Reservoir for Castledermot

CASTLEDERMOT, 1 June 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). Kildare County Council proposes to construct a **new reservoir** at Phillipstown, on the **Castledermot to Rathvilly Road**, and to extend the existing 300mm-diameter water main from Graney into Castledermot - a distance of about 2.7 miles. It will pass through or near a number of **areas of archaeological potential** as identified in the OPW's Sites and Monuments Record.



The measures are part of council **policy to extend water services** to meet the expanding needs of the county and to improve the provision of services in those areas of the county where deficiencies exist at present.

According to acting senior planner **Michael Kenny** (left), the new reservoir is to be located in the corner of a field and adjoins the county boundary with Carlow. The site is 0.25 acres in area and will be screened on its eastern and roadside boundaries while the **reservoir is to be partially concealed** with grass embankments around its perimeter.

The development will also involve the erection of a small control house, new site entrance and fencing.

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Material contravention 'may face court action'



COUNTY HALL & NEWBRIDGE, 31 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). A **material contravention** of the County Development Plan to facilitate a Newbridge developer may be **challenged in the courts**, according to one of the councillors who voted for the rezoning on Monday.

Cllr Emmet Stagg told KNN that he has 'serious reservations' about the decision which provides James Kelly with rezoning of 38 acres (in red above) to build 304 houses at **Rickardstown and Roseberry**, beside a 35-acre site which 'is being disposed of to the Council for housing

purposes'.

He said the councillors were effectively **put in the position** of voting for 38 acres of private housing or 'against' 35 acres for social housing, housing which is so badly needed in Newbridge that 'we didn't have an option'. "There are **600 families on the housing list in Newbridge**, and we had to vote for what was effectively not a good decision," he said.

Cllr Stagg **blames** councillors who represented Newbridge in the formation of the 1996 town development plan for the current situation, where they rezoned 400 acres without making any provision for social housing. "This week we were **voting a wrong** to make up for a previous wrong," he said.

Prior to the vote, Deputy Stagg asked the county manager, **Niall Bradley**, if it was in order for him to consider the fact that there was a 'package' involved, which included a social housing gain to the community. "I think he **answered me very completely** when he said that social housing 'was also a consideration in the planning and development of the area' and therefore it was **in order** for me to have that in my mind when I voted.

"There will be **a number of challenges** to this decision by those who are against it, and I believe the issue of **whether we had the right to vote as we did** will



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certainly be challenged to the **Planning Appeals Board**, and may well **go to the courts.**"

(Full report on the council debate on the issue below)



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Major material contravention to County Plan for Newbridge

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COUNTY HALL, 31 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). The Newbridge site involved in the contravention of the **County Development Plan** last Monday consists of three fields which are the central portion of a larger landholding based at **Rickardstown House**. Access will be from Sex's Road. The contravention was proposed by Newbridge **Cllr John O'Neill** who said that 60% of the 2,000 applicants on the housing list are anxious to live in Newbridge.

In the deal, details of which have not been publicly specified more than the county manager's statement that the price is '**very competitive** as far as the community gain is concerned', 35 acres can be purchased by the Council for social housing.

A number of councillors were of the view that a decision on the material contravention **should be deferred** until a report on the development of the area is to hand within the next few weeks.



Cllr Sean O Fearghail said a number of issues had been raised by members of the local community which 'warrant very serious considerations'. He also **wanted assurance** that the councillors would have an input into deciding what will go on the lands coming to the Council.

Senator John Dardis said councillors had to accept that the proposal would have a major impact on the people living in the area, 'with environmental consequences'. He had **difficulty in understanding** how the bridges in the area could cope with extra traffic and also why a development of this magnitude would not be subject to an **Environmental Impact Statement**. He also noted how an application for a house was recently turned down in the area on the grounds

that the Osberstown Sewerage System 'was not able to cope'.

Cllr Catherine Murphy opposed the contravention, saying it was 'the wrong way to go'. She said consultants are **working on an action plan** north of the railway line in Newbridge for a much broader piece of land and that it seemed strange that the councillors had the contravention in before that report. She **proposed they wait** until the report is available in order to 'have a broader focus'.

Cllr Mary Glennon said material contraventions are 'piecemeal planning'. "At the stroke of a pen today we are **about to make somebody very wealthy**," she said. "What is this person giving back to the community?"

Cllr John O'Neill said he had been fighting for a landbank for Newbridge for years. "We haven't an eighth of an acre available and haven't had local authority houses built in the town for almost seven years." He said the proposal **must take on board** the considerations of people who have lived in the area for years. He also believed all the bridges in the area should be widened.

Senator Jack Wall, who was part of a special committee set up to source land for the council, also **wanted a commitment** that consultations will take place with local residents. He said it was important not to overlook the benefits of recreational facilities for the town.

Cllr John McGinley said councillors had found themselves 'in a very unsatisfactory position'. He said councillors who had represented Newbridge at



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the time of the 1996 Town Plan **should be ashamed of themselves** for not looking after the 'most vulnerable' people at the time. He said he had to 'reluctantly' **support the proposal** because of their neglect to provide social housing. "We have to do a wrong to rectify another wrong. Councillors at that time only looked after people **who made a monetary gain.**"



Deputy Emmet Stagg described the zonings in Newbridge as 'a patchwork quilt' which he said was a disgrace. "Councillors **should be looking at the plan** and not at the letters from landowners." He supported Catherine Murphy's proposal to defer a decision awaiting a report on the area. He also asked county manager **Niall Bradley** if he (Stagg) was entitled to vote on the proposal since he was 'directly influenced' by the fact that the Council would get 35 acres of land for social housing from the landowner. (Councillors considering a material contravention are required to only take notice of an application's merits in terms of 'good planning and development'.)

In turn, **Mr Bradley** said development north of the railway line is a 'logical extension of the town'. He said providing the necessary services of water and sewerage 'was not a problem' as the Osberstown Sewage Treatment plant is nearing completion with a **population equivalent of 80,000**, which could be expanded to 120,000 at the next level of its development.



In response to **Senator Dardis's** account of an application for a house being turned down on the lack of sewerage service, the manager said this '**should not have happened**' and he would look into it.

Mr Bradley said he was **throwing his full weight as manager** behind the proposal, a view which followed a detailed examination of the issues. He said an **EIS is not required** for the number of houses in the application. He promised that there would be full consultations with the Council in future stages of the project. "Everyone that has an input to make **will be listened to** very carefully."

Cllr Murphy then asked what zoned land in Newbridge remains undeveloped. Planner **Michael Kenny** replied that most of the land zoned in 1996 is either 'committed, built on, or spoken for.'



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UDC to share Civic Office with KCC

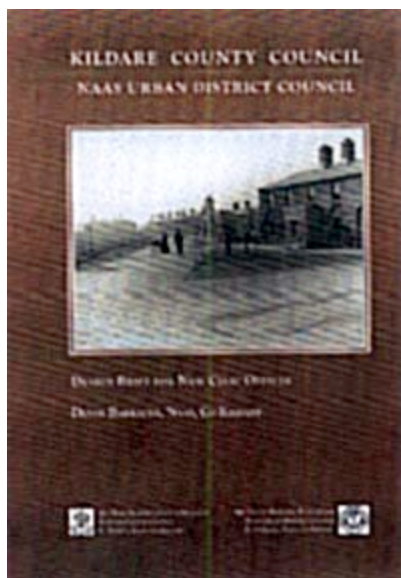
NAAS, 31 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). Almost before the sounds of its **centenary celebrations** have died, Naas UDC has decided to **give away its visual autonomy**, by merging its civic offices with those of Kildare County Council.

This has become official with the production of the **design brief for new Civic Offices** at Devoy Barracks in Naas, which will house both local authorities in the one building.

The brief has been prepared by Kildare County Council's **Architectural Services Department** and provides a background to both the county and county town's locations, demographics and current administrations as well as outlining **future office requirements** for each authority.

In a preface, the document says the move will allow the '**consolidation**' of the provision of local authority services to the people of Kildare and Naas, and will also allow the public to '**avail of other State services**' at the same location.

The document says it is planned to **retain** the existing **UDC Council Chamber** in the Town Hall for council meetings, but all other services will be located at the new Civic Offices. A 'UDC Civic Garden' will be incorporated **near the new offices** to be used for receptions and as a 'welcoming' area for the public during office hours.



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Karen honoured by county council

NEWBRIDGE, 31 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). Newbridge and Ireland hopeful in the 400m event at the **Sydney Olympics**, **Karen Shinkins** (pictured here with her father **TJ**) from Blackberry Lane in Newbridge, was honoured with a **special presentation** 'of a white envelope' and a gift of jewellery at Monday's meeting of **Kildare County Council**.

Afterwards, Karen gave KNN an update of her **recent training visit to Poland** where she said everything had gone well, including the fine weather in the mid-20s which she said was a plus in the run up to the Sydney heat. "I put in **three weeks of very hard work** and got more out of it than I had expected," she said.

Karen plans to stay in her **present top form** by taking part in events in the

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Czech Republic on Thursday. Her hectic schedule also includes Prague on Monday and **Greece** on the following Saturday. "I feel I **need to compete in these races** to see what shape I'm in and if we have to **adjust my training** schedule," she said.

Karen's main fans include her proud parents, TJ and Christina, and her brothers Edward and Conor.

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Why wait for IT...



Naas hosted visit from 'Big Brother' last week



NAAS, 30 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan & Brian Byrne](#). People in Naas going about their normal business on Main Street were **under video surveillance** for much of last week, almost all of them without knowledge of the fact.

The reason was a demonstration of a **Town Centre Surveillance System** organised in conjunction with **Naas Chamber of Commerce**, which used three high-tech video cameras to show in extraordinary detail **practically every movement** of traffic and pedestrian activity on every foot of public space from Super Valu to beyond Butt Mulligan's restaurant. The cameras were **not noticeable** in their special housings (left), and they provided full surveillance as

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clearly at night as in daytime. The flexibility of the system even allows an operator to zoom in to check car tax and insurance discs.



The system allows a number of surveillance 'patterns' to be set so that regular 'trouble spots' can be **monitored more frequently**. Other possibilities are the provision of 'panic buttons' at intervals along the street where anyone

worried about their security could immediately call on the operator to put them in view.

The pictures are recorded to a **computer hard disc system** which can be tailored to cope with any number of cameras for any preferred period of time. Even while any camera is operating, what it has recorded can be viewed, at speeded-up rates to quickly review activity. Pictures which are required immediately can be produced on an **ink-jet colour printer** which is part of the system, while any moving sequence can be **recorded onto a CD** on the spot.

During a demonstration last weekend for press and local business people, an observing garda said **he had seen two 'local criminals'** on screen in a short space of time during the showing and if they had committed any wrong they would have been already recorded doing so.

Sergeant **Kevin Gralton** of Naas Garda Station (right with **Fergus Mooney** of Technique) was also very positive about the system, saying its like are now 'essential' for **every town in the country** and everyone who has seen this system so far is in favour. "It's a crime prevention measure, and **every measure we can get** to prevent crime must be taken. These facilities are fantastic." He said he didn't believe that having such a system in would be used as an excuse to further lower the number of gardai available for street patrol duty.



The president of Naas Chamber of Commerce, **Mary Bhogal**, said they had been prompted to undertake the demonstration after receiving complaints from members about **a spate of window-breaking**. But the cost, estimated at £300,000 for a full system for Naas town centre, could not be undertaken by the traders alone. "It would have to be **a joint venture** from discussions between the chamber, the gardai and Naas UDC." She also said it would **have to be operated** by the gardai.

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That last remark was echoed by the MD of the company demonstrating the system, **Fergus Mooney** of Technique (above left with **Mary Bhogal**, **Hugh Magee**, **Cllr Mary Glennon** and **James Byrne** of Rushe's pub) whose company has the agency for the PELCO remote electronic management systems in this country. "Without the involvement of the gardai, it's dead in the water," he told KNN.

James Byrne and **Hugh Magee** from the Stationery Store were both in favour of the security scheme. **Teresa Green** from Patti's Giftware on the Dublin Road would also like to see it come to town. Her shop window was broken on two occasions.

"It keeps you awake at night thinking about it," she said and wondered would a camera be put on the Dublin Road to take in the few shops there, and the shops around the corner to Quinnsworth Supermarket. **Anne McCormack** from Annmacs Knitwear also favoured the scheme.

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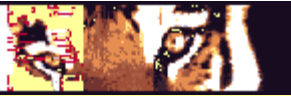
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Clane students achieve Gaisce awards



CLANE, 30 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). Pupils who took part in the President's Award Scheme - **Gaisce** - were recently rewarded for their achievements at a special presentation ceremony at **Scoil Mhuire** in Clane. Pictured above with **Bishop Roy Warke** are Silver Awardees **John King, Stephen McCartan, Julie McBride** and **Eileen Clifford**. Below, with the minister for finance, **Charlie McCreevy TD**, are Bronze Awardees (front) **Finola Campbell, Ann Gilligan, Damien O'Kelly, Meabh Cummins, Mark Kilpatrick**; and (back) **Ciaran O'Reardon, Paul Mullally** and **Mary Cullen** (not pictured is **Ciara Herbert**).

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The Award is the National Challenge Award from the **President of Ireland** to the young people of Ireland. Since its introduction in 1985 it has attracted enormous interest from young people. It is designed to encourage them, regardless of their background, to **develop their own skills** and to **help their communities**, by setting themselves a target programme to be achieved in a given period of time. Gaisce cooperates with the **Duke of Edinburgh Award** in Northern Ireland. The awards scheme is coordinated in Scoil Mhuire by **Mary Foster**.



A number of previous awardees spoke about their involvement in the scheme. They included **Fergus McCormack** (centre in picture), a past pupil, who has achieved both Bronze and Silver awards after fighting to overcome severe disabilities following an accident. **Kevin King** (left in picture), now living in Clare but who worked his Bronze and Silver Award with Mary Foster in Scoil Mhuire, spoke about what he did to receive those awards and his plans to go for Gold.

Teacher **Helena Wilson** (right in picture) outlined her activities in achieving her Gold Award which included involvement with **Clane Musical Society** in their production 'Anything Goes', learning to drive and passing her test, and undertaking whitewater rafting in alpine rivers. She had started her run for Gold in 1996 and completed her target in 1999. She was presented with her Gold Award by the President in January.

Presenting the medals to the students on behalf of **President Mary McAleese**, finance minister **Charlie McCreevy TD** said participating in the programme is a 'wonderful way to instil a high degree of initiative, perseverance, self-discipline and leadership ability'. He said participation in the Gaisce scheme provides young people with **a vehicle to become active participants in society**. He encouraged the awardees to undertake the next level award, be it Silver or Gold, or to become President's Award leaders themselves.

Rt Rev Bishop Roy Warke, who has retired to Naas, is a member of the Council of Gaisce. He said the whole Gaisce operation depends on the programme Award Leaders and said in Clane 'you have one of the **outstanding leaders** in the whole organisation in Mary Foster'. Praising the young awardees he said it is not an easy award to achieve, but is something very worthwhile.



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Punchestown music distracted diners

NAAS, 30 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). Music **blaring from loudspeakers** on a pole outside a restaurant in Naas during the **Punchestown Festival** had prevented diners from engaging in conversation - including discussing the races - a recent meeting of UDC was told.

Cllr Timmy Conway said the Festival had attracted people from all over Europe and all pubs and restaurants had been packed to capacity. "It was a very big boom time for the people of Naas as well as for racegoers - but people dining out could not talk with the noise," he said. He said it was 'a **massive barrage of high volume thunder**' with nobody listening to it.



He referred to a **band at a hotel** which had played until 3am, preventing local residents from being able to sleep. He sought to have all music in pubs turned off at midnight during the Punchestown Festival and that Naas UDC should talk to the **Naas Festival Committee** and the hotel about the situation.

Cllr Anthony Egan asked if the UDC had a function in relation to noise pollution. He said he was not against music in pubs, even until 1am but said there should be some control over the volume.

Officials said the Council has no role in relation to the playing of music in pubs but advised the matter could be considered by the licensing courts when applications are being made for the Punchestown Festival.



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'Nuisance' notice served on dump operator

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POLLARDSTOWN, 30 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). Kildare County Council has served an '**Abatement of Nuisance**' order on the operator of a dump at Pollardstown which is used by several hundreds of trucks every week.

Thomas Munnelly of Loughbrown, The Curragh, has been warned by the council to **remove or cover all organic waste** within seven days and spray the property with insecticide. He has also been told not to accept any further organic waste on the site.

Local people have been campaigning for some time to have the dump closed down. Environmentalists say it represents **a threat to the nearby Pollardstown Fen** (below). Mr Munnelly says he has a licence to accept builder's waste.



Why wait for IT...



Ten years of giving women confidence in themselves





NAAS, 29 May 2000: by [Trish Whelan](#). A mature student **Business and Computers** class at St Patrick's Community College in Naas is a godsend for **women who want to return to work** as well as for the local business community.

When first devised by **Martina Durkin** (above) ten years ago, it was **unique of its kind** in the country. Since then some 240 local people have gone through the one-year programme in Naas, with 225 of them gaining local employment. **Derivatives** of the course are now available countrywide.

Last week saw the **completion of this year's programme** (students pictured below), which Martina describes as 'a **challenge and an opportunity** to local business'. With almost full employment and a critical shortage of staff across a broad spectrum of Irish business, Martina 'challenges' firms to **examine their work practices** to cope with the shortage as she believes taking on an employee from 9 to 5, for a five-day week, may not be the way to go for some firms.



Ninety per cent of her students are **married women** who want to return to the workforce when their youngest child has started school. "Some will work part time, mornings or afternoons, or from home. They are **skilled, dedicated and reliable** and may be the solution to some firms' recruitment problems."

Martina says the course makes people believe in themselves and they lose their fear of technology. "For whatever reason people enrol on the course, we are in the business of **addressing needs on an individual basis**, and no matter how



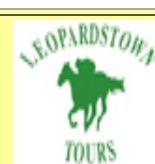
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inadequate you may feel regarding computing or IT, it should not deter you from **catching that tiger** by the tail."

Christmas is the time during the course when students **suddenly feel confident** in themselves with what they are learning and is marked with a night out. In March they undertake a three-week **spell of work experience** with local employers - something which many of them haven't had for years.

The new graduates of the course will get together again in November to receive their certificates. Some 40% will go to full-time jobs, with half the balance opting for part-time work.

Local businesses where her students have got jobs include **financial institutions, Co Kildare VEC, Kildare County Council, auctioneers, insurance companies, accountants, solicitors, stationery shops, Toughline, the Windscreen Centre, Johnstown Garden Centre** and many others.

While most people doing the course come from Naas, the catchment area includes outlying towns such as **Sallins, Straffan, Rathcoole, Kilcullen, Blessington** and **Athy**. All ages can apply, though the lower limit is 21 years. Candidates must attend for interview for the 24 places available each year.

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Phillipa Wolahan (on left with Naas **Windscreen Centre** accountant **Caroline McGlinchy**) did the course because she had spent the last ten years at home and wanted to update her skills to get a job. "I was hoping it would get my brain functioning again into a different mode. I wanted to get back something I had lost," she said.

She had a computer at home but didn't know how to use it. "**All my skills were dated** and I heard about this course from others who had done it. It was nerve-racking at first as I felt I was going back to school - but everybody

else was in the same boat. After a week I found I could do it and that **my brain hadn't shrunk!**". Phillipa also found the social side of the course a big help.

Her work experience was with the Naas Windscreen Centre and she is now back working with the company at their request. "It's all thanks to Martina's course," she says.

Una Healy (right), who runs a B&B on the Clane Road in Straffan, enrolled on Martina's course **to learn all about computers** to help with her business. "After just one year in business I knew I had to update skills as it would take me all day to write a letter at the time," she recalled. So proficient did she become that she now has the **business featuring on websites** and has had a number of bookings by email. She can now do out her menus each day and also hopes to compile her own advertising brochure!

Somehow she also found time to **fundraise for the Telethon** and was





able to type up all her invitations herself. Not content with her new achievements, Una also finds time to attend a course on tourism.

Mum-of-three **Anne Marie Campbell** (left) from Naas had left work to raise her family and enrolled on the course because she wanted to get back into the workforce. She didn't know what to expect when she signed up as she had no secretarial or PC skills. "Meeting **other women in the same circumstances** was great and we all got on very well. It gets you ready to go back to work again"

Anne Marie did her work experience with **Kildare County Council**. She's **available** for part time work from September.



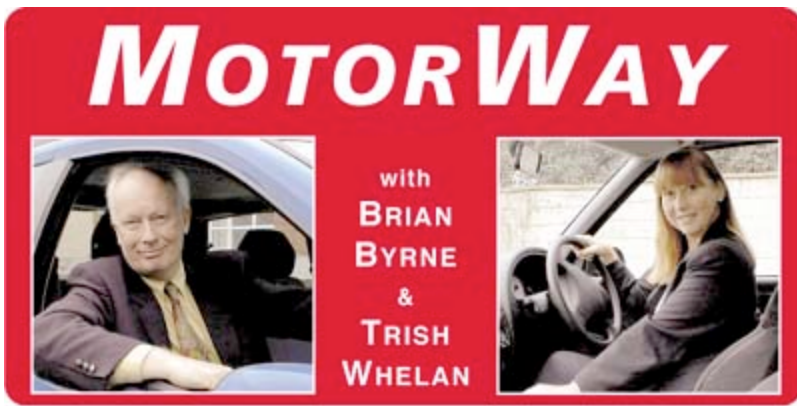
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Car of the Week



[Hyundai Coupe](#)

Jobs target and interest in Millennium Park 'accelerate'

NAAS, 29 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). The job targets of 5,000 for **Millennium Park** in Naas are 'likely to be accelerated' following what the developers describe as a 'continuous stream' of visits by the IDA since the marketing offices for the project were officially opened by the Tanaiste in February.

"They are anxious to present Millennium Park as a leading site option for new companies considering Ireland for their investment," says the CEO of **Bandenberry Ltd, Michael Mullally** (right). "We also expect that the level of interest in the site will accelerate now that we have begun the construction programme for the roads network."



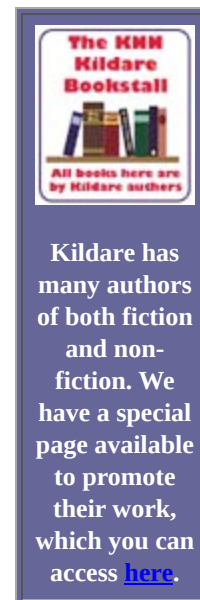
The roadworks begin at the **Sallins Road** end of the development, where a roundabout will be constructed at the **junction with Monread Road**. The completed road, according to Bandenberry, will also fulfil Naas UDC's objective of providing an inner relief road for Naas. It will be augmented by **footpaths and cycle**

tracks along its entire length, and is planned to link with a proposed new interchange on the M7 (above) and **eventually join** with the existing Naas-Newbridge road near Newhall.

The work also includes the construction of a **new sewerage and waste water** network system.

Plans are also at an advanced stage to begin the construction of 175,000 sq ft of **new office accommodation** in the park, with the first two blocks of a six-block development **scheduled for availability** over the next 12 to 18 months.

"This element of the project has the **potential to allow over 1,600 jobs** to be made available in the local community," says Michael Mullally. "If the amount of **unsolicited CVs** being received are any indication, many of these new jobs are likely to be sought by **existing residents of the area**, many of whom are currently having to endure the daily commute into Dublin and its immediate environs."





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Golf club 'needs chemical fertilisers'



THE CURRAGH, 29 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). The **Curragh Golf Club** couldn't maintain its greens without the **aid of chemical fertiliser** and any new regulations for the Curragh Plains area on use of such fertilisers must take this into account, a recent meeting on the Curragh was told.

Member **Paddy Gleeson** said organic fertilisers simply 'can't keep the greens right' and chemical products **must be used**. He suggested that the miniscule amount used during each year would **have little effect on the aquifer** under the Curragh, and a special exemption could be made.

The meeting was under the auspices of the **SRUNA PROJECT**, an EU-backed initiative which is aimed at assessing and planning for the **sustainable recreational use** of natural assets. The Curragh is one of a number of pilot projects in the Dublin Region under the initiative, and the local project has been managed by **Kildare County Council's** Planning Department.

Participants were told that **current regulations already prohibit** the use of chemical fertilisers on the plains, and one sheep farmer who has grazing rights for his sheep in the area said that **if a special case** was made for the golf club, then every other user would be **entitled to special consideration** too.



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New sweepers for North Kildare

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LEIXLIP, 29 May 2000: by [Bill Trapman](#). Kildare County Council is to purchase **two new Johnson 600 mechanical sweepers** – one of which will be assigned to Leixlip, Maynooth, and Celbridge. The news has been welcomed by **Cllr Paul Kelly** (right), who has been demanding ‘a substantial upgrading’ of the street cleaning programme for months.



“I’m glad that things are now moving in the right direction,” he said at the weekend. “The **majority of complaints** I get from the public relate to litter, and up to now the Council have not been taking this seriously enough. As well as the sweeper, we are to get **four people as a ‘support team’** to clean parts of the towns that the mechanical sweepers can’t reach – for example where paths are too narrow or inaccessible for even the smaller Pathfinder machines.

“I think this initiative represents a new commitment by the Council to reduce litter on our streets. However, **litter isn’t dropped by the Council**, but by irresponsible members of our own community. Alongside the action by the Council, we must make sure that everyone plays their part in cleaning up our towns. The Council has a Litter Management Plan which includes education initiatives, assistance to residents associations and other groups, enforcement by Litter Wardens, as well as street cleaning. **None of this will solve the problem** without the people themselves playing their part and joining us in cleaning up all round”.

Noreen McCabe, MNAPCP

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Tourism familiarisation trips

KILDARE GENERAL, 29 May 2000: by [Brian Byrne](#). Kildare Failte is organising two ‘familiarisation trips’ of tourism attractions in County Kildare, and has offered 10 places on each trip to **members of the general public** at an all-in cost of £20 for each trip, which are geared to making staff and operators of tourism businesses **aware of attractions** to which they can direct visitors.

“We feel this is **a great opportunity** for the people of Kildare to experience some of the wonderful attractions that are available in the County,” says KF’s tourism executive **Bertha Cooke**.



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The trip for North Kildare takes place **tomorrow**, Tuesday, leaving Kildare CYMS at 9.30am and taking in **Peatland World, Lullymore Heritage & Discovery Park, lunch at Ballindoolin House, Castletown House and Maynooth College** (above).



The South Kildare event will take place on Tuesday 6 June, departing from the Ambassador Hotel, Kill, and taking in **Ardsclull Moate, Athy Heritage Centre, Moone High Cross, the Irish Pewter Mill, lunch at the High Cross Inn, a tour of Ballitore Quaker Village, Crookstown Mill (right), and the K Gardens** in Nurney.

For further information please contact Bertha at 045-898888 or 087-6960674



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'Embarrassed politicians' comment

NAAS, 29 May 2000:

Dear Editor,

I read with interest your report on the comments of councillor Byrne. While I do have a certain degree of sympathy with him, I am sure that he has to agree that the public have a understandable degree of cynicism when it comes to politicians. His namesake, another Charlie, has made proper charlies of us all and as the tribunals dig more and more, we the public see more and more evidence that the actions of those in power have seemingly nothing to do with the concerns of the public.



Openness in government seems to be an alien concept and it requires the like of these tribunals for the public to get an insight into how the Irish political system works. Of course, you may say that such will not happen in the town of Naas, but is the Naas UDC chamber, as it is currently run, beyond question?

At the last meeting, the public who arrived on time for the public session were asked to leave and wait until the 'in committee stage' was over. The public were only allowed access 30 minutes later. If the business being discussed was of a sensitive nature, then I would understand this. Discussions on individuals and housing allocations might be such matters but apparently this was not completely the case.

Amongst the items being discussed behind closed doors was the predicament of the town's GAA club who have been apparently used as pawns by developers, and the New scout Den. Surely these are areas where the public would like to know what is going on? But no, this information is too hot to handle. When we got in, the chair told the public that the GAA issue had been discussed and the GAA would be able to make a submission to the council the following Tuesday. OK, perhaps the public could attend this, but no, the public, I was told, were EXCLUDED as the session was deemed to be 'in committee', not open to the public gaze.

After the last UDC meeting and the reports on it, my curiosity was raised. I went along to the council offices to get a copy of the previous minutes as I was told they contained a record of a topic dear to my heart - the issue of playgrounds. I looked at the file, and found the last time it was updated was January 2000. I asked for more recent minutes, and was initially told that they weren't available. I asked who was the Freedom of Information officer, I was told who he was but that he had left the UDC. The girl who was assisting me then went upstairs and came back with the requested minutes.

I read them and asked for a copy of the relevant pages. I was initially told that I could only read them. I said that I would be requesting them under the FOI act. She suggested she would discuss this with Declan Kirranne when he returned and would get back to me. Fair dues, her colleague rang me the following day and told me she would be posting out the record I wanted and also answered some general questions I had on the issue. While they did help me, I question the fact that public records were not maintained and it was so difficult to get the information that I pay for, and also the apparent non-replacement of the former FOI officer.

Please note I am not questioning the people who assisted me, just the system that left them ignorant of my rights. In central government I see further evidence of an attempt by politicians to deprive me of a right to have a say. Under the new planning laws, minister Noel Dempsey (FF) is proposing that all those who wish to contribute to the planning process will be charged for the privilege. In the appeals stage (where you currently have to pay also) he is proposing that unless you were involved in the initial stage you have no voice. Many people may not find out about a development until late in the planning process. In regard to charges, the only people who seem to have money to burn are supermarket tycoons and property developers.

So, Charlie, I'm sorry if I am a member of the cynical public and you may be innocently caught up because of the actions of members of your party, but have a look at it from my side of the fence.

John Kavanagh

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